Jay Stewart

Product engineer. I find out what users need, then ship it with coding agents.

Available now for remote contract work

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PROFILE

Product engineer who finds out what users need, then ships it with coding agents. Since March 2026 I have shipped three products solo: SpiralClass, a teacher platform in production that takes real payments through Stripe Connect; WantToJoin, which went from reading a hostel's guest chat to a live pilot there in three days; and Beckon, an end-to-end encrypted inbox for terminal agents, live since October 2026. Before that I spent eight years on e-commerce backends, on systems that hold other people's money. Available for contract work with early-stage startups: MVPs, first versions and product engineering.

EXPERIENCE

Founder & Product Engineer · Independent

Mar 2026 – now

SpiralClass `live · real payments` Scheduling, payments and video for independent teachers, built and run solo. In production with a teacher and her eight students.

- TypeScript end to end: Next.js 16, Postgres through Prisma (82 models), Inngest background jobs, self-hosted LiveKit video, about 870 test files.
- Moved payments to Stripe Connect direct charges on Accounts v2, so the teacher is merchant of record and the platform never holds funds. Added Wise as a second rail, reconciled through its API.
- Release engineering: a merge gate tied to the exact commit pushed, the same definition of green locally and in CI, coverage floors, migration drift checks and a documented database rollback.
- Cut CI spend by tracing about 744 billable minutes a month to one workflow, without making any step manual.

WantToJoin `pilot · one hostel` One page per hostel with tonight's plans, RSVPs and a live meeting pin.

- Read 2,800 messages from five months of a hostel's guest WhatsApp group before writing code. The finding changed the product: build for the hostel's social hosts, not the guests, with the hostel as the buyer.
- Reviewed the competition (Hostelworld Linkups, SocialStay) and built only what they don't offer: no app to download, a live meeting pin, and a minimum headcount with a deadline.
- From research to a live pilot in three days; 129 commits on Cloudflare Workers and D1, with PostHog analytics. Every user-facing change tested in a real browser at phone width.
- An AI post writer drafts each post in English and Spanish with Claude Haiku, checked in code: all 50 eval drafts pass, at about $0.0003 a post.

Beckon `live · open source` A remote inbox for terminal agents: approve or deny a waiting Claude Code session or build from your phone's lock screen. Live since October 2026, no outside users yet. Source: github.com/jaystewartuk/beckon.

- Found the problem in recurring Hacker News threads, then wrote the spec first: user flows, a security model, acceptance criteria and explicit non-goals.
- End-to-end encrypted. Devices pair by comparing a six-word safety code; the helper types a response only after checking its signature, the trusted device, the record revision and the offered option.
- A Go helper that wraps commands in a pseudo-terminal, a Next.js, WebSocket and Postgres service, and an installable web app with push notifications.
- Moved production off Cloud Run to one hardened VM: key-only SSH, read-only containers, a least-privilege database user, nightly encrypted offsite backups with a rehearsed restore, and a dead man's switch on monitoring.

Career break Mar 2020 – Mar 2026

A planned break after eight years in e-commerce, travelling on savings. Back in March 2026 because coding agents changed what one person can ship.

Backend Engineer · G&V | Venture Brands Agency (contract) · Bristol Jul 2017 – Mar 2020

- High-traffic e-commerce platforms, including Dyson's store. Custom backend modules for stores handling transactions and customer data at scale.
- Fixed production issues where an outage meant lost orders, working with client engineering teams against fixed launch dates.

Backend Engineer · Thrive Chiropractic (contract, remote) Aug 2016 – Mar 2020

- Designed and built a booking and payment platform from scratch, and ran it for nearly four years: real-time scheduling, secure payments, and the reporting the practice used to make decisions.

Backend Engineer · Folk Digital · Bournemouth Jul 2014 – Aug 2016

- Backend features and third-party integrations for performance-sensitive e-commerce clients.

Backend Engineer · C3 Media · Bristol Jul 2012 – Jul 2014

- Went from junior PHP developer to building and maintaining full e-commerce systems on my own.

HOW I WORK

- **I start with users.** I talk to them in person, read their real conversations, and change the plan when the evidence points somewhere else.
- **Experiments have a stopping rule.** A hypothesis, what gets built, what gets measured and when to stop are written down before the code.
- **Agents write a lot of the code, and I own the result.** Pull requests, CI gates and testing in a real browser, so quality doesn't depend on a reviewer happening to notice a problem.

SKILLS

Product	User interviews, analysing chat and usage data, competitor research, experiment design, pilots with real customers
Building with agents	Claude Code, parallel agent sessions in git worktrees, CLAUDE.md conventions, evals, CI gates and browser testing to verify agent output
Stack	TypeScript, Node, Next.js, React, Postgres, Prisma, Go, Cloudflare Workers and D1, Inngest, LiveKit, WebSockets; PHP and Magento before 2020
Payments	Stripe Connect (direct charges, Accounts v2), Wise reconciliation, Mercado Pago (an earlier version)
Operations	GitHub Actions, Docker, Google Cloud Run, a hardened Hetzner VM, encrypted offsite backups, uptime and heartbeat monitoring, Sentry, PostHog
Languages	English (native), Spanish (working)